trimTAB

Strategic Interventions. Outsized Results.

FOR CPG FOUNDERS & OPERATORS

The Plan Is the Easy Part

9 ways to turn a 2027 plan into a 2027 result

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Before we begin

If you're reading this in late 2026, your 2027 plan is probably done, or close to it. The budget is built, the targets are set, and the team is ready to go.

That's real work, and it matters. It's also just the first part of the work. Planning takes a month or two, and delivering on the plan takes the whole year. That's where the year is won: in how a team keeps its focus, reads its numbers, adjusts when conditions change, and pulls together when things get tough.

I've spent more than 20 years in operations, from large global enterprises to fast-growing, founder-led consumer brands. Over that time, I've watched well-conceived plans both hold up and quietly come apart within the first few months. The difference was rarely the plan itself. It was the operating habits around it.

This booklet shares nine of the best-practice habits that, in my experience, make the difference. None of them is complicated, and you may already be doing several. They're simple to understand and harder to do consistently, which is why they're worth writing down.

Take what fits your business and leave what doesn't. Every company is different, and nobody knows yours better than you do.

Here's to a strong 2027!

Sujit Srinivas
Founder, Trimtab



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01

Find the 20% that delivers 80% of your 2027.

Most leaders know the 80/20 rule: a small share of what you do drives most of your results. The vital few and the trivial many. If everything is equally important, nothing really is.

Your 2027 plan holds dozens of initiatives, and every one of them matters. A handful, however, will decide the year. Find those few and resource them properly, with the right people, money and attention.

Your 20% might be:

- A new retailer launch that carries a big share of your revenue growth
- A manufacturing change that adds several points of gross margin
- A new distribution footprint that cuts freight cost without hurting on-time, in-full
- A marketing program built to bring a wave of new consumers to your brand

Not sure what yours are? An effort versus impact grid sorts them quickly. Plot each initiative on it, and the few that matter most stand out.

Knowing your 20% also makes delegation easier. You and your leadership team can give the vital few your full attention, and confidently hand off the rest.

If everything is equally important, nothing really is.

EFFORT VS IMPACT



The top row is where your 20% lives. Resource it first.

02

Measure your business, not someone else's.

Dashboards are easy to love. They make decks look pretty and meetings look busy. Yet the number of KPIs you track matters far less than whether they're the right ones.

Metrics borrowed from a book or another company's deck often say little about your business. Worse, they can make everything look fine when it isn't. Eight to ten metrics built around how your business actually works will beat forty off-the-shelf ones every time.

The best KPIs give you both lagging and leading indicators: how you've performed, and how you're likely to perform. Most importantly, they give you the insight to act and get the business back on track.

Let your business choose them:

- Customers paying late? Track days sales outstanding.
- Losing product in production? Measure yield loss, and the work underway to improve it.
- Frequent out-of-stocks? On-time, in-full, inventory days, and forecast accuracy and bias belong on your list.

KPIs can and should be customized. One size doesn't fit all. Start with the numbers that tell you how your business is really doing, and build from there.

Ten metrics that fit your business beat forty that don't.

A GOOD KPI

1. **Looks back.** Shows how you've performed.
2. **Looks ahead.** Signals where you're heading.
3. **Drives action.** Tells you what to do while there's still time.

If a metric can't influence a decision, it doesn't belong on the dashboard.

03

Put a name on every number.

Accountability starts with clarity. Every key metric and initiative needs one owner, and everyone around them needs to know their role. A RACI matrix (responsible, accountable, consulted, informed) is one simple way to make that explicit. There are other methodologies available too, so pick one that works for your team.

Without clear owners, things slip. When they do, the conversation turns to who was supposed to handle it, and that's never a productive place to be. A regular cadence of check-ins keeps the work on track and surfaces issues early.

Here's the part that's often missed: ownership is as much about support as it is about accountability. The buck may stop with the owner, but they still need help from everyone else.

A named owner has a clear place to say what's working, what isn't, and what they need. Without that, the job can get lonely very quickly.

Putting a name on every number holds people accountable, and makes sure the right people get the support to deliver.

Ownership is as much about support as accountability.

ONE NAME, ONE RHYTHM

Gross margin
Head of Operations · Monthly

On-time, in-full
Supply chain lead · Weekly

Days sales outstanding
Controller · Weekly

New retailer launch
Head of Sales · Every two weeks

Illustrative examples. Each number gets one owner and a set time to review it.

04

Run one forecast, not three.

In many companies, three forecasts live side by side, and they rarely meet. Sales has one, usually optimistic. Operations has one, usually conservative. Finance has one, often trend-based and adjusted to hit the financial targets. None of them may be close to reality.

The cost shows up everywhere: stock-outs or excess inventory, mixed messages to the board and investors, long explanations after the fact of why the numbers missed, and finger-pointing.

Much of this pain is avoidable. It starts with a single source of truth for demand and a monthly sales and operations planning (S&OP) process that balances demand and supply. As the business matures, that can grow into integrated business planning (IBP): the same monthly rhythm, extended to include the product portfolio and innovation, capital expenditure planning, and longer-range strategic and financial planning, with the executive team more deeply involved as it steers the business forward.

The team reaches consensus on one forecast, grounded in the realities of the business, and is accountable to it. If it misses, you find the root cause and fix it together, rather than defending three different versions of the truth.

This takes work, collaboration and, in some companies, a cultural shift. It's time well spent. One forecast turns separate functions into one team working toward one goal.

One forecast turns separate functions into one team.

THE MONTHLY PLANNING RHYTHM

1 Portfolio review

↓

2 Demand review

↓

3 Supply review

↓

4 Financial reconciliation

↓

5 Management business review

↓

One agreed latest estimate

Every function, the same numbers, the same sequence, every month.

05

Let the map guide you while you steer around the weather.

By March, your actuals will likely look different from your plan. That's normal. Nobody has a crystal ball.

Think of a road trip from Portland to New York. You've planned the route, the stops and the days on the road. Then come road closures, bad weather, an accident on the freeway. You wouldn't respond by heading to Miami instead. You'd add a buffer day, pick a cheaper hotel, and make whatever adjustments are needed to still reach New York close to on time, with enough money left in your pocket.

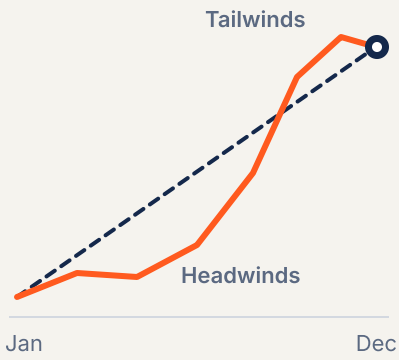
Your plan works the same way. Keep it locked as your destination, and use a latest estimate (your current outlook for the year) to show where you're actually headed. The gap between the two tells you how to adjust the route.

Watch tailwinds as closely as headwinds. When something beats plan, press the advantage rather than coasting into complacency. Tailwinds don't last.

A monthly S&OP or IBP rhythm makes this routine. Arriving at or near your destination, despite the weather, builds real credibility with your board, your investors and your team.

Change the route, not the destination.

PLAN VS LATEST ESTIMATE



Plan: locked, your destination

Latest estimate: the route

The plan stays fixed. The latest estimate shows the gap, and the gap tells you where to steer.

06

Make the hard calls while it's calm.

A few months into the year, usually by the end of the first quarter, you'll see how actuals compare with your plan. Sometimes they're close. Sometimes they're far apart, and the gap keeps widening.

First, don't panic. Second, don't lean on optimism either. It's easy to keep funding the same things and tell yourself that results are just around the corner. As time slips by, that story gets harder to unwind.

So decide your triggers in advance, while things are calm: the point at which you'll act, and what you'll do when you get there. When a trigger trips, you're not starting from scratch. You already have a framework for responding, which you adapt to the best available information at the time. You're deciding how to act, not whether to act.

These calls are tough: deferring hires, pausing a program that isn't delivering, reallocating budget to protect margin or revenue goals. Made early and deliberately, they keep the company healthy and stable.

They also show your board, investors and team that you're being proactive and that your decisions are grounded in reality, rather than in chasing a number that every sign says won't come.

Decide the trigger before you need it.

EXAMPLE TRIGGERS

If revenue runs 10%+ under plan for two straight months, **then** defer the hires tied to that growth.

If a marketing program misses its leading indicators after 90 days, **then** pause the remaining spend and reallocate it.

If gross margin trails plan by 2+ points at the end of Q1, **then** review pricing, mix and promotional spend.

If a sourcing or cost-saving project slips a quarter, **then** pull forward the next one on the list.

Illustrative examples. Set your own with your team before the year starts.

07

Guard your cash as hard as you chase sales.

The P&L and the balance sheet can tell very different stories. Sales are strong, margins are healthy, EBITDA looks great, and cash is still tight. It's one of the most common traps in a growing CPG business.

Treat cash the way you'd run your household. A credit card can carry you for a while, but someday the bill comes due. Know how much cash you have and where it's going.

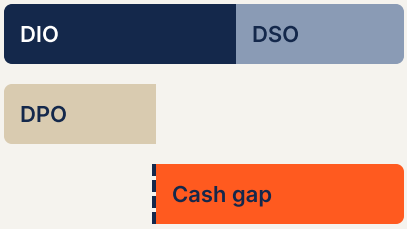
Start with the cash conversion cycle: how long a dollar spent on inventory takes to return as cash. Three levers drive it:

- **Days inventory outstanding (DIO).** Set an inventory policy for weeks on hand, and avoid tying cash up in excess stock, including stock driven by co-packer and supplier minimum order quantities (MOQs).
- **Days sales outstanding (DSO).** Agree on sound payment terms with customers, and chase late payers.
- **Days payable outstanding (DPO).** Build partnership-based terms with suppliers, rather than paying on delivery.

While the cash conversion cycle is one important factor, other outflows compete for the same cash. Examples include slotting fees, trade spend and retailer deductions, equipment and debt payments, and lump-sum payments that hit cash all at once (typically spread over time on the P&L), like annual bonuses, taxes, insurance premiums and software prepayments. Keep the cycle tight and outflows visible, and growth won't walk you into a cash bind.

A profitable business can still run out of cash.

THE CASH CONVERSION CYCLE



DIO + DSO − DPO
= cash conversion cycle

DIO: days your cash is locked in inventory before it turns back into cash

DSO: days it takes to get paid by customers

DPO: days you take to pay your suppliers

The orange bar is the number of days your cash is tied up. Shorten it with any of the three levers.

08

Build a system for anything you do twice.

Many teams rebuild the same analysis by hand every week or month, often in a spreadsheet. That creates two problems.

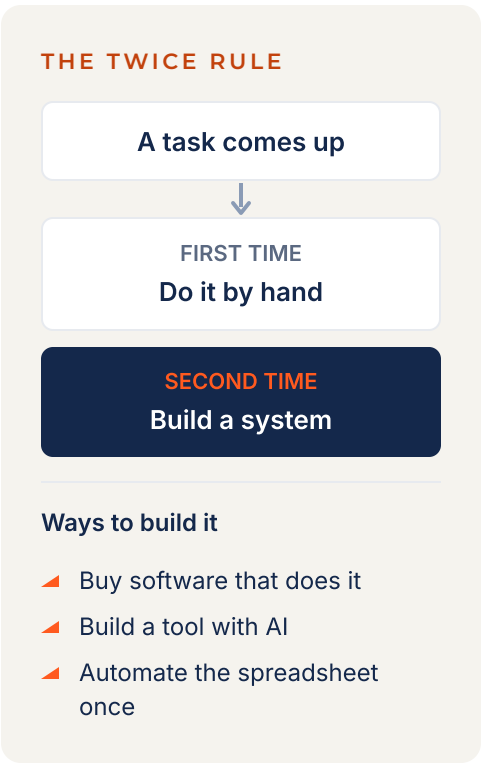
The first is a single point of failure. When the one person who knows how is on vacation or leaves the company, you're back to figuring it out from scratch.

The second is time. Spreadsheets are fantastic for one-off analysis, and a poor home for routine work that's rebuilt from first principles every cycle.

So here's a simple rule of thumb. If you're doing something for the second time, it's a sign it should probably become a system. That could be software you buy, a tool you build with AI, or a spreadsheet macro built once and reused. Get it out of people's heads and into a system.

One-off analyses will always happen, and that's fine. When a task becomes routine, systematize it. The work gets faster, more predictable, less error-prone and less dependent on any one person. Just as important, the time you save on the busy work of routine tasks can be reinvested in fresh ideas and future-focused innovation that raise the bar.

Do it once, by hand. Do it twice, build a system.



09

Celebrate the wins, own the misses.

Individual accountability matters. Someone who goes above and beyond shouldn't go unnoticed, and a lack of effort shouldn't be excused. However, this is about something else: the team as a whole, and making it greater than the sum of its parts.

We work in a predominantly virtual world and we're entering the age of AI, but people are still a company's most important resource (hopefully for a long time to come). That calls for real camaraderie.

Every so often, take a breather as a team to reflect on the great work that's been done, and celebrate it together. It sounds easy, yet teams often get so consumed by execution that they forget to do it.

The harder part is owning the misses together, without finger-pointing. When a goal is missed despite everyone's best efforts, acknowledge it as a company. Then ask how teammates can step in and help close the gap.

Think of a good sports team. When a player has an off night, the others step up, and next time it may be the other way around. Departments can do the same; if one has a rough quarter, another can push harder. Production hits a snag? Perhaps sales can reset customer expectations early while finance finds room in the budget.

Shared incentives make this easier. In my experience, bonuses tied to shared company metrics keep everyone pulling together far better than highly individualized, department-specific targets, which tend to build silos.

The whole should be greater than the sum of its parts.

OWNING A MISS TOGETHER

THE MISS
A cost-reduction project slips

↓

THE TEAM
Sales finds more volume with a high-margin customer

THE MISS
A marketing investment underdelivers

↓

THE TEAM
Operations fast-tracks a cost project from six months to two

Illustrative examples. Everyone owns the miss. Everyone helps close the gap.

LET'S TALK

Small adjustments, big year.

If you'd like to discuss any of these habits in more detail, need help putting them in place for your team, or have anything else on your mind for 2027, I'd be glad to hear from you.

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Strategic Interventions. Outsized Results.

Trimtab is a fractional COO practice for founder-led consumer goods companies.

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